

Financial Aid Basics — Federal & State

Going back to school or training? Federal and state financial aid can cover much of the cost — and a lot of it is free money you never repay. Below are the official starting points. Tick the box once you've done each one.

⚠ BEFORE YOU START

The single most important step is filing the FAFSA — it's free and unlocks grants, work-study, and loans. Never pay a service to file it for you; the official site is free.

1 Start With the FAFSA

One free form unlocks most financial aid, including free grants.

☐ File the FAFSA — Free

The key to federal and state aid. "FAFSA" literally means FREE Application — never pay to file it.

→ studentaid.gov/h/apply-for-aid/fafsa

☐ StudentAid.gov — Aid Overview

Understand grants, work-study, and loans before you borrow.

→ studentaid.gov/understand-aid/types

2 Free Money: Grants

Grants don't have to be repaid — always max these out first.

☐ Federal Pell Grant

Up to about \$7,395/year for students with financial need. A new "Workforce Pell" (starting July 2026) also covers shorter job-training programs.

→ studentaid.gov/understand-aid/types/grants/pell

☐ State Grant Programs

Your state likely has its own grants. Filing the FAFSA often applies for these automatically.

→ studentaid.gov/resources/state-contacts

3 Work-Study & Smart Borrowing

Earn while you learn, and borrow wisely if you must.

☐ Federal Work-Study

Part-time jobs to help pay for school, arranged through your college.

→ studentaid.gov/understand-aid/types/work-study

☐ Federal Loans (Borrow Last)

If you must borrow, federal loans have better terms than private ones. See the Student Loan Help guide.

→ See: **Student Loan Help guide**

4 Get Free Help Applying

Free, trustworthy help with the FAFSA and aid.

☐ Federal Student Aid Help

Free help by phone or chat with your FAFSA and aid questions.

→ studentaid.gov/help-center/contact 1-800-433-3243

⚠ WATCH OUT FOR

Never pay to file the FAFSA — the real site is studentaid.gov and it's free. Avoid "scholarship" or "aid" services that charge fees or guarantee money; legitimate aid never works that way.

★ A TIP THAT HELPS

File the FAFSA as early as you can each year — some aid is first-come, first-served, and filing early can mean more free grant money.

NEED HELP WHERE YOU LIVE?

Need help where you live?

This guide covers federal aid. For your state's grants and deadlines, use the personalized AI search or ask in the Questions area, and we'll help you find them.

MY NOTES — WHO I CALLED, WHEN, AND WHAT THEY SAID
